THE LANGUAGE OF SCENT

Making fragrance easier to understand.

A visual exploration of scent categories, notes,
and the relationships behind fragrance descriptions.

MIDTERM PROJECT

SeungYeon Choi

Why is fragrance hard to describe?

Perfume descriptions mix scent families, recognizable notes and subjective impressions.

FAMILY

Floral

The broad scent category.

NOTE

Rose

A specific, identifiable scent.

DESCRIPTOR

Sweet

A quality used to describe a scent.

The issue is not a lack of perfume information, but how overlapping terms and combinations are explained.

How the concept evolved.

An initial discovery-and-recommendation idea shifted toward understanding fragrance information first.

01

INITIAL IDEA

Visualize scents, identify preferences and find similar perfumes.

02

EXISTING SERVICES

Perfume search and recommendation tools already exist.

03

DISCOVERED GAP

Terms overlap; mixtures and sensory descriptions are difficult to interpret.

04

DESIGN DIRECTION

Organize fragrance concepts and make their relationships visible.

INTENDED EXPERIENCE

I want users to understand what fragrance terms describe through clear definitions, familiar scent references, and interactive connections.

By exploring families, notes, and descriptors, users can see where terms overlap and where they differ.
Instead of presenting every relationship at once, the website reveals relevant information step by step through selection.

Choosing a useful family framework.

The Perfume Society's eight-family system is a starting point; other professional frameworks divide fragrance differently.

- Fresh
- Floral
- Floriental
- Ambrée
- Gourmand
- Chypre
- Woody
- Fougère

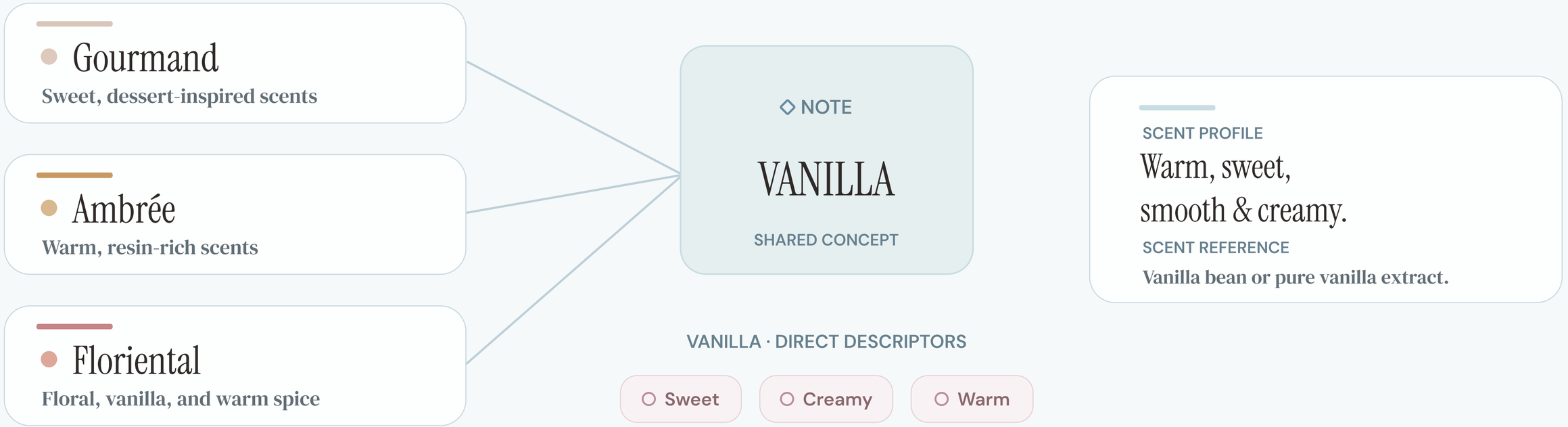
Decisions behind the information structure.

Different terms, overlapping relationships, and abstract scent descriptions shaped the design.

01	SEPARATE THREE INFORMATION TYPES	Clarify the roles of Family, Note, and Descriptor.
02	START WITH EIGHT FAMILIES	Give users a clear entry point before the details.
03	KEEP DIRECT, SHARED CONNECTIONS	Link shared concepts across families without duplication.
04	USE FAMILIAR SCENT REFERENCES	Make abstract scent descriptions easier to imagine.

One concept. Multiple connections.

Vanilla is a single note linked to several fragrance families.



Links explain scent associations. They are not measured similarity scores.

Not every connection means the same thing.

Family–Note, Family–Descriptor, and Note–Descriptor links are defined separately.

01 / FAMILY–NOTE

32 LINKS

Fresh ↔ Lemon

A family can include a particular note.

02 / FAMILY–DESCRIPTOR

34 LINKS

Fresh ↔ Clean

A family can carry a sensory quality.

03 / NOTE–DESCRIPTOR

43 LINKS

Lemon ↔ Citrusy

A note has its own linked descriptors.

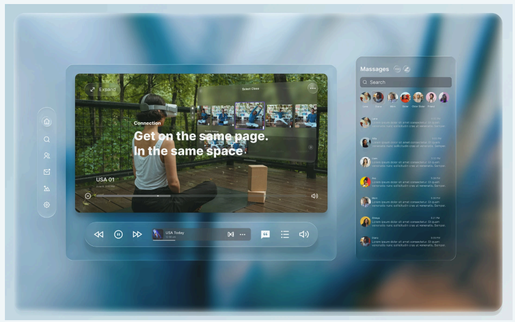
08 FAMILIES 23 NOTES 15 DESCRIPTORS 109 CURATED LINKS

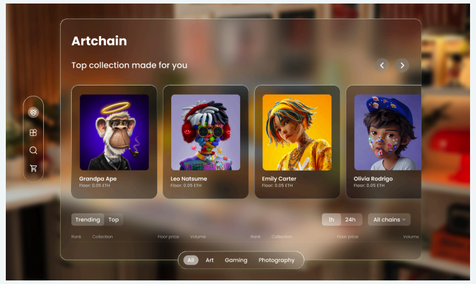
Fresh → Clean does not mean Lemon → Clean. Only direct Note–Descriptor links apply.

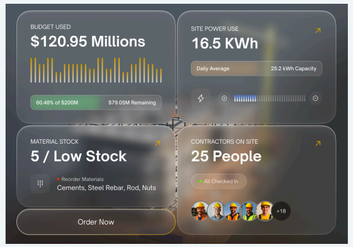
References & moodboard.

Visual and interaction references alongside the atmosphere I want the website to communicate.

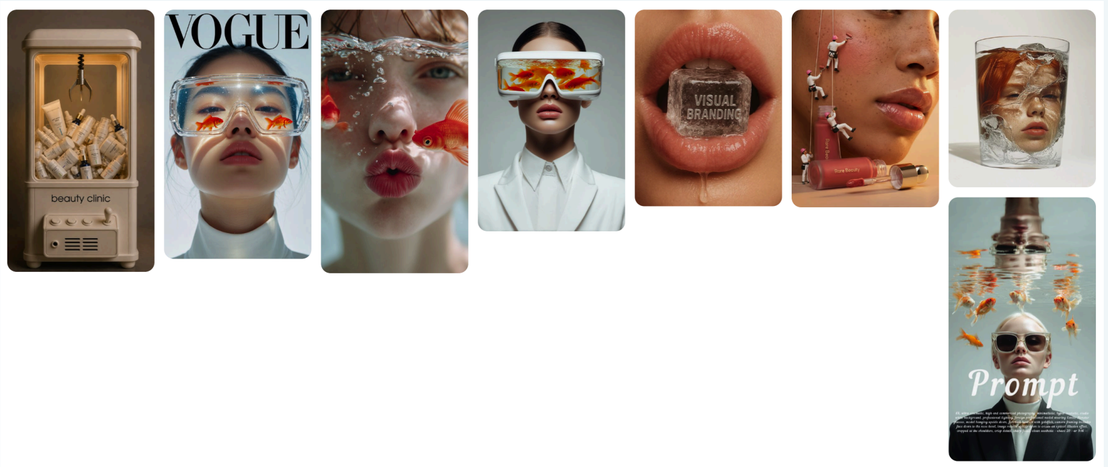
DESIGN & EXPERIENCE REFERENCES







MOOD / VISION BOARD



Transparent Nude White + Experimental Beauty Editorial.

Neutral white and nude tones give scent families room to stand out; a clean laboratory-inspired structure makes their relationships easier to follow.

SOFT WHITE
#F7F6F3

GLASS GRAY
#DDE2E5

WATER BLUE
#C8DDE2

MUTED ROSE
#C98688

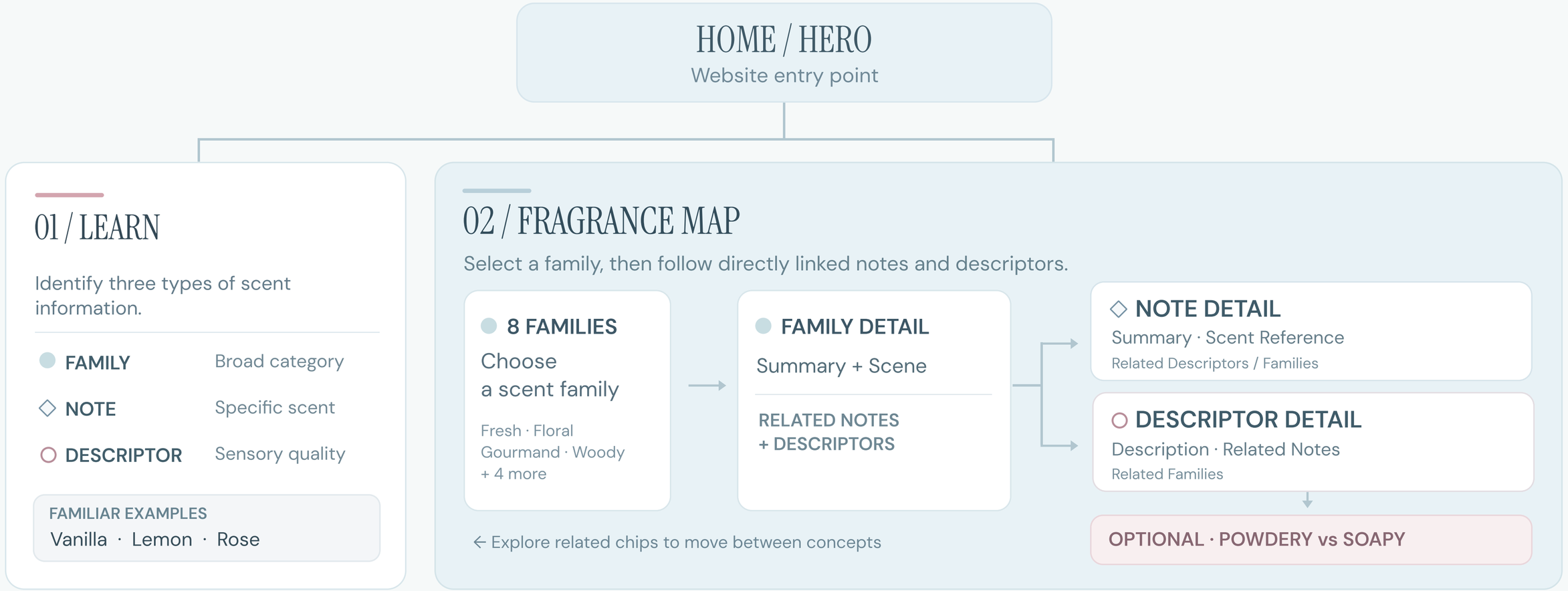
CHARCOAL
#302B28

A refined, sensory interface.

Instrument Serif + DM Sans / Liquid Glass-inspired layers were added to express transparency and depth, not as the original concept.

From concepts to connected exploration.

A closer look at the Learn section and the interactive Fragrance Map.



A journey through connected scents.

Example flow: choose Floral, follow Musk to Soapy, compare with Powdery, then return.

01 / START

LEARN

Understand Family, Note and Descriptor.

02 / EXPLORE

FLORAL

Select one of eight families.

03 / FOLLOW A NOTE

MUSK

See its scent reference and related descriptors.

04 / INVESTIGATE

SOAPY

Explore its meaning and related notes.

05 / COMPARE

SOAPY / POWDERY

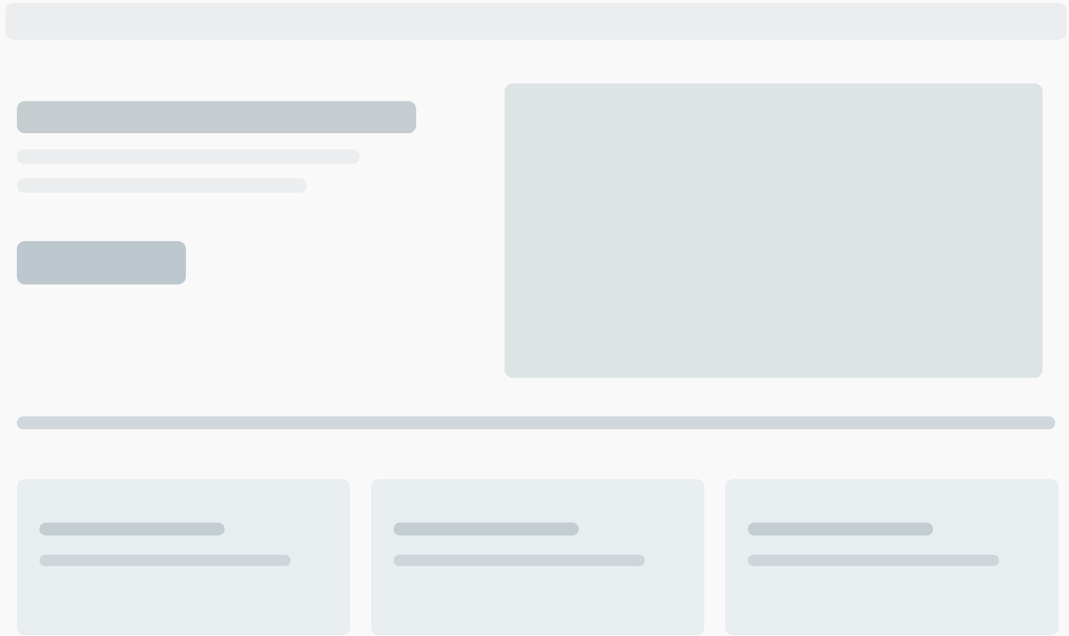
Compare the terms; return to Map.

AFTER COMPARISON ↶ Return to the selected concept or Fragrance Map to explore further.

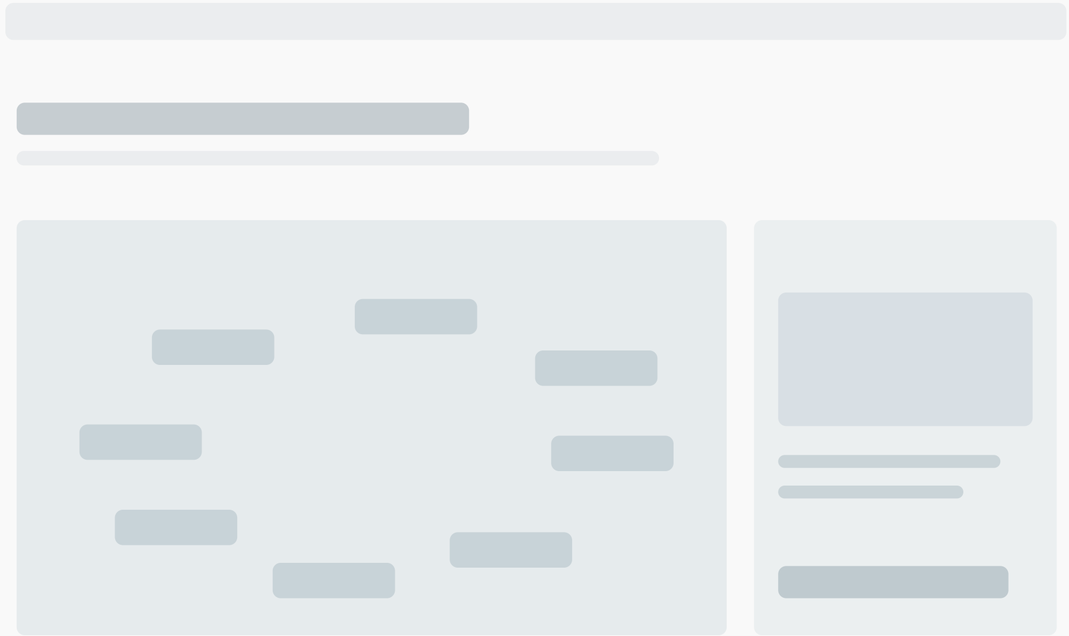
Wireframes - layout and hierarchy.

Early layouts for the homepage, Learn, and Fragrance Map before visual styling.

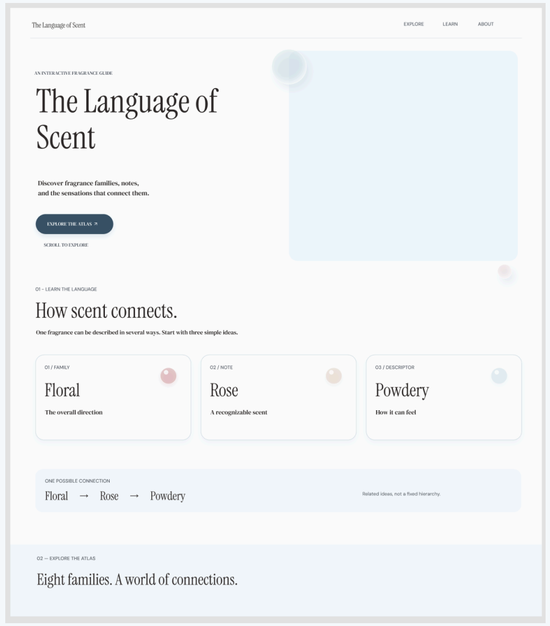
01 / HOMEPAGE + LEARN

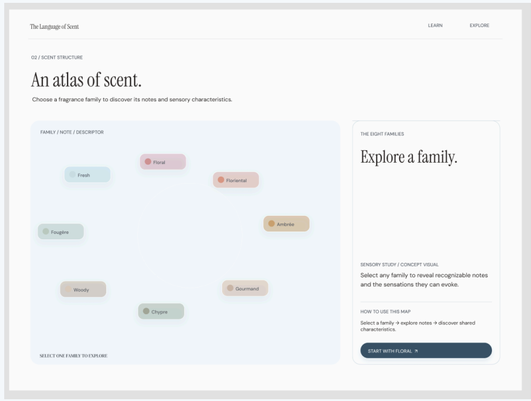


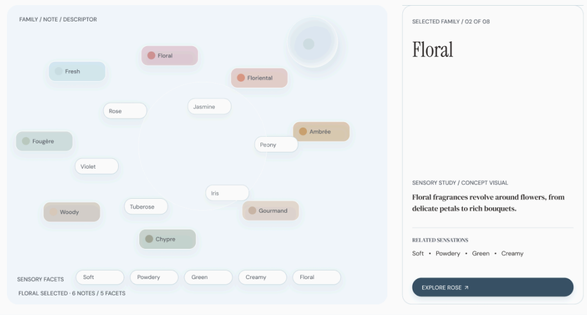
02 / EARLY FRAGRANCE MAP



Initial Website Designs







From comparison concept to working prototype.

An early visual idea remains exploratory; the live site has a simple side-by-side comparison.

01 / THE CHALLENGE

Similar words, different impressions.

Powdery suggests a soft, dry texture. Soapy evokes scented soap or freshly washed skin.

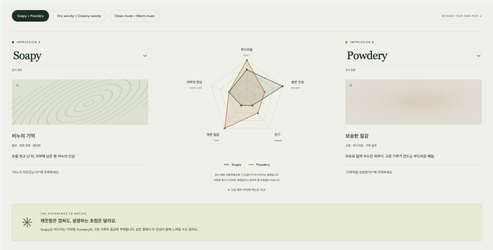
02 / WORKING PROTOTYPE

Basic side-by-side comparison

Selecting Soapy or Powdery opens a working comparison with descriptions and sensory visuals.

Descriptor → Compare → Understand

03 / EARLY VISUAL CONCEPT



A more detailed radar-chart view was explored but is not implemented yet. The comparison could be developed further.

Responsive & Interaction

Mobile reorganizes the map and details into a sequential, touch-friendly exploration.

DESKTOP

Map + detail panel

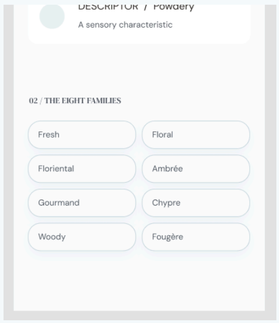
Spatial relationships and explanations can be viewed together.

MOBILE

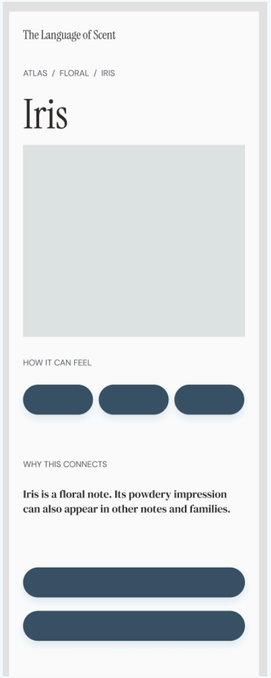
Selected concepts and their details are stacked for focused, touch-based navigation.

MOBILE VIEW 01





MOBILE VIEW 02



EARLY MOBILE STUDIES / FINAL SITE USES TWO-COLUMN FAMILY CHOICES AND STACKED DETAILS

Reflection & Next Steps

I originally wanted to help people visualize scents, identify their preferences, and discover similar perfumes. While exploring existing services, I realized that understanding the fragrance descriptions themselves was a challenge worth addressing first.

The most difficult part was organizing overlapping fragrance terms and relationships without making the experience complicated. This led me to simplify the classification, keep shared connections, and reveal details through selection. I am still exploring how sensory comparisons can be made more intuitive.

Next, I plan to further improve the responsive experience and refine the website through user feedback.

Research references: The Perfume Society; The Fragrance Foundation France; Michael Edwards / Fragrances of the World.